North American AJ Savage

1948

BOMBER

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The first naval combat aircraft designed to carry an atomic bomb and for a time the world's largest carrier based aircraft, the Savage was developed (as the North American NA-146) to meet a US Navy requirement for a high performance attack bomber capable of carrying a nuclear weapon.

In order to meet the specification's demands a large aircraft was required, this in turn dictating the need far an unusual composite powerplants configuration - a pair of Pratt & Whitney R-2800 Double Wasp radials as the primary engines augmented by an auxiliary Allison J33 turbojet in the lower rear fuselage.

This third engine was intended to provide a high speed 'dash' capability during the attack phase of the aircraft's operation and for extra boost on takeoff when required. Other features included shoulder mounted folding wings, tricycle undercarriage, wing tip fuel tanks and (on the first models) dihedral tail planes.

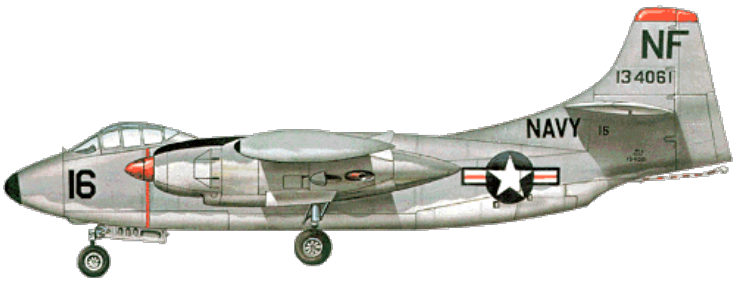
The Savage was ordered In June 1946, the first of three XAJ-1 prototypes flying on 3 July 1948. These were followed by 55 initial production AJ-1s, the first one flying in May 1949.

Deliveries to US Navy squadron VC-5 began in September 1949 and the first carrier landings were performed aboard USS Constellation in August 1950.

The AJ-2 first flew on 19 February 1953, this upgraded model featuring revised versions of the same powerplants, increased fuel capacity, systems modifications, a taller fin and no tailplane dihedral.

Preceding the AJ-2 bomber was the photo-reconnaissance AJ-2P (first flight 6 March 1952) equipped with 18 cameras for day and night photography at high and low altitudes, photo-flash bombs in the weapons bay, automatic control of most of the cameras, the associated electronics equipment in a modified nose and additional fuel capacity. Four US Navy combat squadrons were still operating the AJ-2 in 1958 and these received AJ-2Ps.

A number of AJ-1s and AJ-2s were converted to flight refuelling tankers with a hose-and-reel unit installed in the weapons bay. The few Savages still in service in September 1962 when all USAF and USN aircraft designations were combined into the existing Air Force system were redesignated A-2A (AJ-1) and A-2B (AJ-2).



Specification

MODEL	AJ-2

COMPANY PROFILE

All the World's Rotorcraft

CREW	3	
ENGINE	2 x Pratt & Whitney R-2800-44W, 1790kW + Allison J33-A-19 auxiliary turboprop, 2087kg	
WEIGHTS		
Take-off weight	23973 kg	52852 lb
DIMENSIONS		
Wingspan	22.91 m	75 ft 2 in
Length	19.20 m	63 ft 0 in
PERFORMANCE		
Max. speed	758 km/h	471 mph

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Shirley Wood, e-mail, 26.07.2009 21:40

My late husband Alfred R. Wood flew the AJ2 out of Patuxent River and was deplooyed in VC7 to Port Lyautey in Oct. 1953. Would like to hear from any former squadron members.

reply

John Rowe, e-mail, 07.06.2009 22:40

I was based at NAAS Sanford, Fla. from 1953 to 1956 with VJ-62. I served overseas with Detachments Charlie, Fox and Love from 1954, 1955 & 1956. In 1957 the Squadron moved to NAS Norfolk, VA. when it was VAP-62 and I was discharge as a PN2 in 1957. I really had a wonderful time during the entire 4 years. Let me hear from you if you can.

reply

Mario A Pancino, e-mail, 06.08.2023 **John Rowe**

Hi John
I am writing a book on Cold War steins and found your information on the internet.
I am trying to research a stein named to "Dave"
Who served VJ-62(?) with Detachment Charlie in the NELM area from May to Oct 1956.
If you can help, please contact me at collwrld@att.net or give me a call @ 818 /720-1100
Thank you in advance
Mario Pancino

reply

Frank Voltoline, e-mail, 07.06.2009 21:07

I was based in Sanford,Fl. with VJ-62 1952 1955< We deployed to many areas in Europe. I made Detachment Fox and Love, both in Turkey.I have quite a bit of History on the Sqdrn. I still live in the Sanford area.

reply

Capt. Jack, e-mail, 28.05.2009 22:34

Any of them left, static or flying?

reply

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JERRY G. KELLEY, AE-2, e-mail, 28.05.2009 03:52

I joined VC-5 from AE A school at NAS Jax in 1952, and ended my 4 year tour with the squadron in 1955 which included 2 deployments to Port Lyautey [now Kenitra]. & the Med. for NATO operations. Great group, completely dedicated to keeping an unreliable plane in the air. [cont'd]

reply

William Mihay, e-mail, 04.05.2009 21:05

CRASHED IN THESE AJ 2S THREE TIMES. THE FIRST TIME WAS BAD. WE CAME IN TOO HIGH AND FAST. WHEN THE PLANE HIT THE DECK, IT BROKE UP INTO THREE PARTS--THANK GOD THE TAILHOOK HELD AND THE PARTS STAYED TOGETHER. THAT WAS ON THE INTREPID IN NOVEMBER OR DECEMBER OF 1954 DURING CARRIER QUALIFICATIONS. AFTER RETURNING FROM A MISSION IN EARLY 1955 OUR AJ2 PLANE BECAME TANGLED IN THE BARRIERS DURING A LANDING ON THE LAKE CHAMPLAIN. THAT WAS IN THE MED IN EARLY 1955. LATER THAT SPRING IN 1955 WHILE LANDING ON THE CORAL SEA, WE LANDED SO HARD THAT THE WINGS BETWEEN THE ENGINES AND THE FUSILAGE CRACKED. SOME OF MY FELLOW CREWMATES WERE KILLED IN THE AJ AFTER I LEFT THE SQUADRON FOR MY DISCHARGE IN JULY 1955. MY SQUADRON WAS VC 8, STATIONED AT PATUXET RIVER NAVAL AIR STATION, PORT LEAUTE NORTH AFRICA, AND ABOARD THE CARRIERS--INTREPID, THE LAKE CHAMPLAIN, AND THE CORAL SEA. VC 8 WAS TRANSFERRED TO SANFORD, FLORIDA IN AUGUST OF 1955.WE FLEW MOCK BOMBING MISSIONS IN THE US, EUROPE, AND TURKEY. WE DID PHOTO RECONNASANCE IN NORTHERN GREECE, AND REFUELED JETS IN MID-AIR IOVER THE MEDITERRANEAN SEA. I WAS AN AVIATION ELECTICIAN, SECOND CLASS PETTY OFFICER

reply

Buz Sawyer, e-mail, 21.04.2009 04:55

Well, I have finally found a picture of the first plane I ever flew in. I was a yeoman attached to the Service Test Division at Patuxent River, Md. When one of the pilots learned that I had never flown he took me up on a test hop up the East Coast. I stayed in the Navy, converted to Photo Intelligenceman and then was selected for Limited Duty Officer (Intelligence) finally retiring in 1982 as a Commander. Still remember that first flight!

reply

Floyd Williamson, e-mail, 26.03.2009 21:27

I flew as 3rd crewman on the AJ in VAH 7, in Sanford, FL from Aug 1954 thru March 1958 and loved the plane. We flew off "Straight Deck" Carriers and spent a considerable time just circling above the carrier with a full tanker load in case someone was running low on fuel. We only had 3 AJ's aboard each carrier due to their size and was usually the first to launch and the last to land. I have "Dumped" many hundred gallons of AV gas, to get down to landing weight.

reply

Mike Zimmerman, e-mail, 18.01.2009 03:17

Hi - I'm building a model of the never completed USS United States, CVA-58. The Savage must have been the nuclear bomber contemplated for the carrier and I will need to build 12 Savages (1 /700 scale). Can you help me with plans? Thanks

reply

Carl Bachle, e-mail, 24.12.2008 16:18

The AJ was the Navy's response to the USAF B-36: a plane that could deliver nuclear weapons of that era, from the three CVB carriers, anywhere in the world. In turn, this justified building a fleet of larger carriers, a major USN goal as the Cold War continued indefinitely.
For us pilots, the AJ was a cranky beast to fly: sluggish, complex, lots of bugs. Its A3D replacement was better.

reply

Oleg, e-mail, 30.11.2008 10:31

Dear Sirs,
Now I build 1 /72 Savage kit from MACH 2. Maybe somebody know about size of wheel and tyres, used on AJ?

reply

Neil F. MacDonald, e-mail, 30.10.2008 22:42

My oldest brother was a crew chief /flight engineer on AJ's. He is a retired ADJC. Murdoch A. MacDonald. He can be reached at:Murdokay@yahoo.com Lives near NAS Whidbey Island.

reply

Tom S., e-mail, 17.08.2008 09:18

I am currently writing a technical reference for the history of airtankers in the US. I'd be interested in hearing from anyone with images or documentation on the AJ's used in this role.

reply

J U'Ren, e-mail, 23.07.2008 02:47

On Sept 17, 1966, an AJ-1 crashed just down the street from our house in North Hollywood, CA. This AJ-1 operated by AJ Airtankers out of Burbank, CA, was configured as a chemical bomber to fight forest fires in the western US. Unfortunately, this AJ-1 lost an engine shortly after departure from Burbank and went down 3.3 miles from Burbank Airport. Sadly, the pilot was lost in the crash but his last minute decision to bank the plane away from several homes saved numerous lives in our neighborhood on that day. Hats off to all pilots who face difficult decisions at difficult times and manage to minimize

collateral damage.

reply

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Joe, e-mail, 21.07.2008 19:31

Specifications list the third engine as an Allison J33 'Turboprop'. Firstly, I believe the J33 was a 'Turbojet'--no propellor, and secondly, being mounted in the aft belly of the aircraft would not allow room for a propellor.

reply

AT 2 Bill Joyner, e-mail, 02.06.2008 00:08

I was in SQUADRON VC6 AT NORTH ISLAND NAS, SAN DIEGO,IN 1953-1955. I DID MAINTENANCE ON COMMUNICATION AND NAVIGATION EQUIPMENT. I WENT ABOARD THE ORISKANY FOR FLIGHT QUALIFICATIONS, THE FIRST PLANE LANDED AND THE PROPS HIT THE DECK. IT WAS SENT TO THE HANGER DECK. THE NEXT PLANE PULLED THE ARESTING CABLE OUT AND WAS COUGHT BY THE BARRIER.IT WENT TO THE RIGHT AND HIT THE ISLAND AND KILLED ONE OF THE DECK PERSONELL. THE AJ 2 WAS A BEAUTIFUL PLANE BUT HAD MANY ACCIDENTS.

reply

Speedy, e-mail, 22.05.2008 03:29

I'm a military hobbist and I have a little question. Maybe someone know something about a conventional bombload of the Savage? I found on Joe Baugher's website home.att.net /~jbaugher4 /newa2_2.html only one option, 6 x 1600 lb bombs but I think there must be more combinations? Of course I know that all (or almost all) Savage bomber were configured only for one nuclear store.

reply

Capt. W.E.Donnelly USN {ret}, e-mail, 01.05.2008 21:46

I was a Weapooneer /Pilot in VC-5.The Navy's First Atomic Weapons Delivery Squadron. We transitioned from special modified P3Vs to the AJ-1. Later as a test pilot at PAX River I conducted the service test evaluation of The AJ=2. A very difficult aircraft to maintain due primarily to hydraulic problems,but in retrospect The AJ series was the Navy's first carrier based nuclear weapons delivery aircraft.

reply

John Sickel, e-mail, 30.04.2008 02:38

The Carrier was in fact CV-43. My father was with VC-5 at the time. He later served as Air Ops on CV-64 more than a decade later.

reply

Bob, e-mail, 25.03.2008 13:18

I was in VJ-61 from 1952-56 at N.I. and Miramar and I am searching for anyone who may have served with me at that time, and I am searching for any pins /patches specifically for VJ-61 to add to my Jacket. Now living in MN.

Thanks Guys.

(email to: weatherguesser@military.com)

reply

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